Even considering this, the distinction between what they believe is good for them and what they see as good for the nation is striking. This explains why Modi shifted the election discourse from jobs to wider touchpoints like nationalism, dynasty politics and other similar themes.

These survey numbers also explain why Brand Modi fared better in the 2019 election than the economic numbers might have suggested. There is no question that Modi's second government, especially after the pandemic disruptions, faces a huge economic challenge, with several worrying indicators pointed to an upcoming reckoning. Yet, RBI surveys showed that people did not feel the economy had reached a crisis point until at least mid-2020, for this to override other factors.[27] Voters were worried, but their concerns may have been mitigated by the novelty of the targeted DBT schemes (as shown in Part I of this book), as well as their judgement on the political alternatives to Modi, the party's new caste alliances and its cultural signalling.

Figure 10.3: The Rise and Fall of Public Expectations on India's Economic Future (2012–2020)

